

Clockwise from right: Curiously small stills at The Macallan distillery; Exceptional oak casks; Euan Kennedy, Master Distiller at The Macallan

"For me, whisky is never just what's in the glass," says Kennedy. "It's about what that glass allows—the moments, the conversations, the connection." That philosophy runs through everything The Macallan does today.

From Acorn to Glass: Owning the Journey

Much has been said about The Macallan's obsession with sherry-seasoned oak casks. What is less spoken about—and far more fascinating—is how deeply that commitment now runs. The Macallan no longer simply 'sources' its casks. It owns the process.

From forests in North America and Spain to cooperages in Jerez, from seasoning sherry wines to toasting oak to exact specifications, the brand has vertically integrated its entire cask journey. As Kennedy says: This isn't a supplier relationship any more; it is a shared ecosystem. "We talk about acorn to glass," he says, "but we really live it."

Each cask begins with years of air-drying oak, followed by construction in Spain, seasoning with bespoke sherry wines for up to two years, and finally a journey to Scotland. By the time a Macallan 12-Year-Old reaches the glass, nearly 17 years of preparation have already gone into that whisky. It's patience layered on patience. And it shows.

Depth Over Dram

If there is one word the Master distiller uses repeatedly, it's depth. Not as a tasting descriptor, but as a mindset. Depth of flavour, yes. But also depth of thinking. Depth of commitment. Depth of responsibility. The Macallan famously uses no artificial colouring. Every hue in the glass comes from the cask alone—a detail that may seem small until you understand what it demands.

"At our scale, choosing natural colour is actually very difficult," he admits. "People expect consistency—of flavour and colour. That means, we examine every cask, repeatedly, across its life." It's craftsmanship that doesn't announce itself loudly but rewards those who pay attention.

Whisky as a Social Language

Travelling through Asia— and more recently India— Kennedy's observations record something that exciting: People no longer treat whisky as something formal or intimidating. In Singapore, Hong Kong, and increasingly India, whisky is being welcomed into everyday rituals—Friday nights after work, long dinners with friends, quiet celebrations that don't need an occasion.

"The Macallan can be both things," he says. "It can sit